9 TIME IS IGNORANCE

Do not ask
about the outcome of my days, or of yours,
Leuconoe—
it's a secret, beyond us.
And don't attempt abstruse calculations. (I, 11)

There is a time to be born and a time to die, a time to weep and a time to dance, a time to kill and a time to heal. A time to destroy and a time to build.[77] Up to this point, it has been a time to destroy time. Now it is time to rebuild the time that we experience: to look for its sources, to understand where it comes from.

If, in the elementary dynamic of the world, all the variables are equivalent, what is this thing that we humans call "time"? What is it that my watch measures? What is it that always runs forward, and never backward—and why? It may not be part of the elementary grammar of the world, but what is it?

There are so many things that are not part of the elementary grammar of the world and that simply "emerge" in some way. For example:

- A cat is not part of the elementary ingredients of the universe. It is something complex that *emerges*, and repeats itself, in various parts of our planet.
- A group of boys on a field decide to have a match. They form teams. This is how we used to do it: the two most enterprising would take turns choosing the players they wanted, having tossed a coin to see who would have first pick. At the end of this solemn procedure, there were two teams. Where were the teams before they were chosen? Nowhere. They *emerged* from the procedure.
- Where do "high" and "low" come from—terms that are so familiar and yet are not in the elementary equations of the world? From the Earth that is so close to us and that attracts. "High" and "low" *emerge* in certain circumstances in the universe, as when there is a large mass nearby.
- In the mountains, we see a valley covered by a sea of white clouds. The surface of the clouds gleams, immaculate. We start to walk toward the valley. The air becomes more humid, then less clear; the sky is no longer blue. We find ourselves in a fog. Where did the well-defined surface of the clouds go? It vanished. Its disappearance is gradual; there is no *surface* that separates the fog from the sparse air of the heights. Was it an illusion? No, it was a view from afar. Come to think of it, it's like this with *all* surfaces. This dense marble table would look like a fog if I were shrunk to a small enough, atomic scale. *Everything* in the world becomes